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TEACHER GUIDE

Using the Differentiated Student Handouts

A guide to self-selection and flexible differentiation · In Their Hands

WHAT'S INCLUDED

Each Mini Museum lesson plan includes three color-coded student handouts at different challenge levels. Students choose which level they want to work on based on how they feel about the topic — not on a permanent ability label. Here is how the three levels look in the Grades 5–8 Religion lesson, *Whose Image Is This?*

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

"I want more support."

Simplified vocabulary, more scaffolding, visual aids.

IN WHOSE IMAGE IS THIS?

Read the passage in short parts, label the coin's image and inscription, finish the sentence *I carry God's image, so…* and draw yourself as a coin.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

"I'm ready for a challenge."

Grade-level work, done independently.

IN WHOSE IMAGE IS THIS?

Explain the trap and why Jesus' answer escapes it, compare the coin with Genesis 1:27 in a chart, and write a paragraph of reflection.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

"I want to go deeper."

Extension activities, open-ended challenges.

IN WHOSE IMAGE IS THIS?

Weigh three readings of Jesus' answer, apply the Catechism to a modern case, and design a coin for the Kingdom of God.

HOW TO USE THESE HANDOUTS

Five steps

1 Print what you need

All three levels, or just the ones you expect to use. Each prints on its own soft tint.

2 Label by color

Set the stacks out under clear signs, or in color-coded folders.

3 Let students choose

Say it plainly: *this is about the challenge you want today, not about how smart you are.*

4 Normalize switching

If a student wants a different challenge, let them switch. It builds metacognition.

5 No justification

Students don't have to explain why they chose their level.

WHAT EACH HANDOUT INCLUDES

All three levels cover the same core concepts — the same coin, the same passage — but adjust the complexity of the vocabulary, the amount of scaffolding, the depth of analysis required and the independence expected. Every level connects to the exhibition's coins, asks for reflection, and can be completed in class or at home.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Student self-selection of challenge level (sometimes called *differentiation by choice*) has been shown to increase student motivation and engagement, develop metacognitive skills, reduce anxiety around differentiation, build a growth mindset, and allow teachers to differentiate without public tracking.

LANGUAGE MATTERS

SAY THIS

"Choose the challenge level that feels right for you today."

"Green gives more support. Yellow is grade level. Red goes deeper. All three are good choices."

"You can switch levels anytime."

AVOID

"Green is for struggling students."

"Red is for advanced students."

"Why did you pick that level?"

WHY SELF-SELECTION WORKS

Choice without labels

- ✓ **Removes stigma.** No public ability grouping. Students aren't labeled "low" or "high."
- ✓ **Allows flexibility.** A student might choose Green in a subject that feels unfamiliar and Red in one where they feel confident.
- ✓ **Respects daily variation.** A student may choose differently on a tired Monday than on an energized Thursday.
- ✓ **Builds agency.** Students learn to recognize when they need support and when they want a challenge.
- ✓ **Differentiates without labeling.** You meet diverse needs without fixed groups.

ADAPTING FOR YOUR CLASSROOM

If you prefer to assign levels	You can still use these handouts by giving specific levels to specific students, based on your knowledge of their needs. The materials work both ways.
If you want to modify them	Treat each handout as a starting point: leave out a part, add a question, or shorten the writing to suit your class.
If you only want one level	That's fine too. Use whichever level best matches your class.

THE GOAL

Every student engages with the core content at a level that challenges them appropriately. Some need more support to reach the content. Some need extensions to stay engaged. Most are ready for grade-level work. All deserve choice and respect.

QUESTIONS?

These handouts are designed to make differentiation easier for you, not harder. If something isn't working, adjust it. The structure is a tool, not a rule.

Most importantly: the handouts are optional. The lesson plan itself provides everything you need. The handouts are an additional resource for extending learning, providing practice, or sending work home.

Every In Their Hands lesson plan — PreK–K, Grades 1–2, Grades 3–4, and Religion, Social Studies, Math and Art for Grades 5–8 — has its Green, Yellow and Red handouts beside it at minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/in-their-hands/resources.